

Install from source.

01

One verified script prepares, builds, checks, and starts the local desktop app.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Use macOS 12 or later, or Windows 10/11, with Git and internet access during first setup. Run Terminal or PowerShell as a normal user. Setup uses an existing compatible Node.js runtime or downloads a private pinned copy.

Public source: <https://github.com/adammalin/Map-Maker-Studio>

Mac - Terminal

```
git clone https://github.com/adammalin/Map-Maker-Studio.git \  
"$HOME/Map-Maker-Studio"  
cd "$HOME/Map-Maker-Studio"  
/bin/zsh scripts/setup-macos.zsh
```

Windows - PowerShell

```
git clone https://github.com/adammalin/Map-Maker-Studio.git \  
"$env:USERPROFILE\Map-Maker-Studio"  
Set-Location "$env:USERPROFILE\Map-Maker-Studio"  
powershell.exe -NoLogo -NoProfile -ExecutionPolicy Bypass \  
-File ".\scripts\setup-windows.ps1"
```

RELAUNCH OR UPDATE

Mac relaunch /bin/zsh "\$HOME/Map-Maker-Studio/Start-USA-Map-Studio.command"

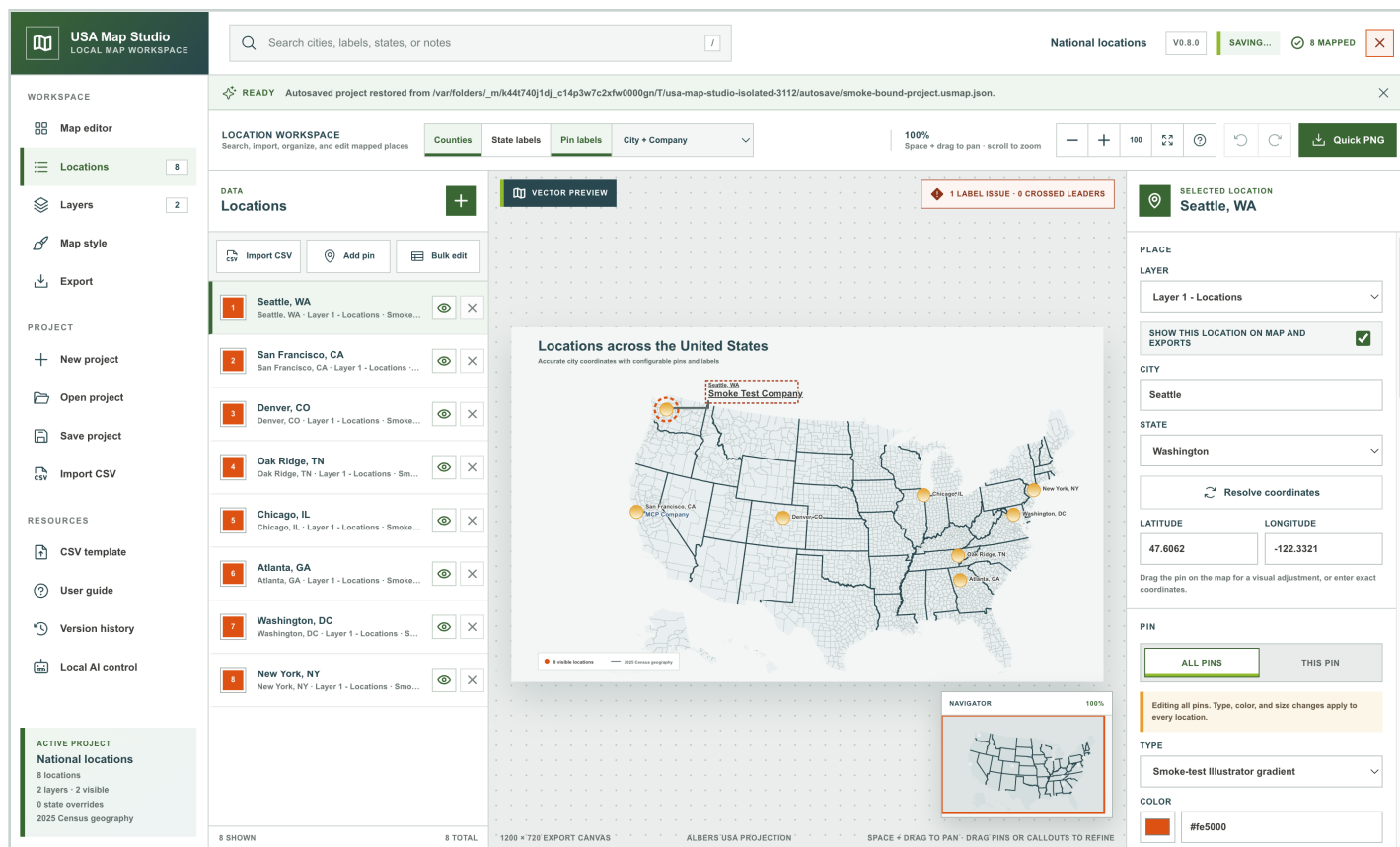
Windows relaunch & "\$env:USERPROFILE\Map-Maker-Studio\Start-USA-Map-Studio.cmd"

To update, close the app and rerun the setup command above. A clean main checkout safely pulls the latest release before rebuilding and testing. Setup creates no DMG, PKG, MSI, or EXE installer and makes no system-wide changes.

Build the map visually.

02

A focused canvas, named layers, location list, and inspector keep every change visible.



1 MAP EDITOR

Choose Pins, City, City + Company, selected-layer, or selected-location labels; then arrange and review lines.

2 LOCATIONS

Open Bulk edit for City, Company, layer, and visibility; use the inspector for exact row styling.

3 LAYERS

Name, reorder, show, hide, and count separate location groups. Set one shared pin style.

4 MAP STYLE

Control fills, boundaries, county lines, label halo, abbreviations, and legend.

MAP CONTROLS AND SHORTCUTS

Hold Space and drag anywhere to pan; drag a pin without Space to move it. Dragging a callout locks its saved position. Arrange labels checks text collisions and crossed leaders. Scroll at the pointer or use +/- to zoom; 0 Fits and 1 returns to 100%. Project keys: Cmd/Ctrl+S Save, Cmd/Ctrl+O Open, Cmd/Ctrl+N New, Cmd/Ctrl+Z Undo, / Search, and ? Shortcuts.

Import data. Keep it whole.

03

Flexible columns feed a versioned project file that can be saved and reopened.

MINIMUM CSV

Two columns are enough

```
city,state  
Oak Ridge,TN  
Seattle,WA
```

Add company labels

```
city,state,company  
Denver,CO,Front Range Components
```

OPTIONAL VISUAL FIELDS

- **Multiple label rows**
company adds a Company row; label_2, label_3, and custom_label_1 add ordered Custom rows beneath the City row.
- **Pins**
All pins is the default editing scope. Switch to This pin for one location. Type, color, size, and custom SVG choices follow that scope.
- **Visibility and data**
visible hides the complete location; show_label hides its callout. Notes and unknown columns remain in project JSON.
- **Map unfamiliar columns**
Open Column mapping in the import review when a client uses headings such as Town or Vendor. Then choose a target layer and Add or Replace.
- **Bulk edit**
Use the data table to change City, State, Company, layer, pin visibility, or callout visibility across selected rows.
- **Save and recover**
Schema 6 stores label views and complete map data. Version history retains up to 24 manual or automatic recovery points.

COORDINATE RULE

When latitude and longitude are blank, the app matches city and state to one of 32,350 representative points from the 2025 U.S. Census National Places Gazetteer. If both coordinates are supplied, the app preserves them. An unresolved place stays out of the map and appears in the import issue list so it cannot be plotted silently at the wrong location.

Export editable slide objects.

04

SVG, PNG, PowerPoint, and project JSON share one composition.

1 SVG

Scalable vector artwork with a named group for each visible location layer.

2 PNG

A 2400 x 1440 raster image for documents, email, and quick review.

3 PPTX

Editable states, labels, lines, pins, and a layer legend with unique city counts.

4 JSON

The complete project: export viewport, label formatting and placement, layers, data, and embedded pin artwork.

GOOD WORKING SEQUENCE

- 1 Save and capture a version**
Choose a .usmap.json path. Open Version history before a major edit or rely on rotating automatic recovery points.
- 2 Arrange and review labels**
Run Arrange labels, review text and line warnings, then drag and lock exceptions. Exports reuse the active saved label view.
- 3 Run export preflight**
Review hidden data, missing Company names, canvas bounds, line crossings, fonts, and PowerPoint editability before writing output.

TROUBLESHOOTING

Setup fails: rerun the setup script; it repairs dependencies and rebuilds safely. A city is unresolved: add exact coordinates or use the official Census place name. Missing company: use Bulk edit or switch to City names. Crossed leader: run Arrange labels, then drag and lock an exception. Autosave fails: keep the app open, check the status chip, and create a recovery point before continuing.

LOCAL DATA BOUNDARY

Normal editing, place lookup, map rendering, and export run locally. USA Map Studio does not send CSV or project content to a service. Files are written only to locations you choose. The bundled map and place data come from U.S. Census Bureau 2025 Cartographic Boundary and Gazetteer files.

Let AI prepare. You decide.

05

ChatGPT desktop, Codex, and compatible local clients can stage map changes for review.

1 KEEP THE APP OPEN

The setup script registers `usa_map_studio`. Restart the AI client, open USA Map Studio, then use `/mcp` to confirm the connection.

2 ASK FOR A DRAFT

The AI reads the named open project, uses its current timestamp, and stages one proposal. No map or saved file changes yet.

3 REVIEW IN THE APP

Compare Before and After. Apply or Reject. After Apply, check the canvas and autosave status; Save is only needed to choose a file path.

CONNECTION COMMANDS

Register or repair

```
Rerun the normal platform setup script
# Restart ChatGPT desktop or Codex, then use /mcp
```

Remove managed connection

```
Mac: Remove-USA-Map-Studio-MCP.command
Windows: Remove-USA-Map-Studio-MCP.cmd
# Unrelated MCP settings remain in place
```

WHAT THE AI CAN DO

Read

Check app status, read the project, list ordered layers or locations, and validate project JSON.

Prepare

Create or change layers, target CSV imports, shared pin style, and complete multi-row label callouts with stored typography and lines.

Cannot bypass review

Write tools create one pending proposal. They cannot click Apply or write an export. After you Apply, the app's normal autosave behavior takes over.

Stale changes stop

If the working map changes after the AI reads it, the proposal must be rebuilt from the current project.

PRIVACY BOUNDARY

The bridge listens only on this computer and uses a new random token for each app launch. Project data stays local until a read tool returns it to the connected AI conversation. Use only an AI client approved for the map content. ChatGPT web cannot directly reach this private desktop bridge; that would require a separate hosted plugin.

Import a pin. Reuse the palette.

06

SVG artwork stays with the project, and named ORNL swatches stay one click away.

CUSTOM SVG PIN WORKFLOW

1 IMPORT

Choose All pins or This pin, select Import custom SVG pin, and open a vector-only .svg file up to 500 KB.

2 SHARE

Keep All pins selected to guarantee the same SVG, color, and size everywhere; use This pin for an exception.

3 SAVE

The sanitized SVG is stored inside .usmap.json. Move or share that one project file without losing the pin artwork.

PRIMARY



ORNL Green
#00662C



Hale Navy
#00454D



Graphite
#DBDCDB



Polar
#FFFFFF



Dark Matter
#373A36

SECONDARY



Energy
#7DBA00



Mist
#8BFEBF



Biome
#00B38F



Aqua
#00BDB5



Infinity
#006BA6



Hydro
#005776

ACCENT



Forge
#FF9E1B



Spark
#FE5000



Plasma
#B50094



Pulsar
#4E008E

SAFE BY DESIGN

The importer keeps safe Illustrator gradient and stroke styling while removing scripts, event handlers, external references, embedded raster images, unsafe styles, and unsupported elements. ORNL swatches are a draft aid: check contrast, use accents sparingly, and complete normal communications review before release.